

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 15



CHAPTER 15



"SAIL, HO-O-O-O-O!"

That night as their boat took Nat and Captain Prince across Funchal Bay to the *Astrea*, Nat was still thinking about the legend of Machico. Maybe, he decided, before they weighed anchor, he'd write a letter to Elizabeth. There were several things he could tell her, about Lisbon, about the women who sold the fish, and about the legend of Machico. Or perhaps he'd keep that to tell her when he saw her. Perhaps he'd tell her about that, and then —

They boarded the *Astrea*. At the first glimpse of Collins' face, Nat knew something was wrong. Even before Collins spoke, Nat guessed that Lem was in trouble again. Nat had guessed right. For the third time, Lem Harvey was in the brig.

"That's the end of it!" Prince roared. "Hereafter,

someone else will drill the men at the guns!" He strode below.

Collins shook his head. "Now we will have trouble with Lem! Oh, for a good, rousing battle with a privateer! Or, better yet, a running fight — all the way to the Cape. That would keep Lem out of trouble."

"What's the matter with Lem, anyhow?" Nat asked.

Collins shrugged. "Lem was just born that way; born to fight. When he can't fight in a good cause, he just fights anyhow. There's no way to stop him. I could spread-eagle him, and give him three dozen lashes. He'd just swagger about his work with his back running blood."

Nat's stomach churned. "There ought to be some other way."

Collins raked him with a disgusted glance. "There isn't. Lem Harvey's born to trouble. He did pretty well while he was drilling the men; that let him work off part of his meanness. Now — heaven help us!"

The end of May they stood out from Madeira and headed south. Tom Owens took over drilling the men. Lem glowered and muttered under his breath. His sullenness seemed to hang over the whole crew. Nothing a man could put his finger on — but everything took twice as long to do as it should.

It was almost a relief one day when a sudden squall hit them and had the men fighting like demons to reef sails before the masts snapped. Something to struggle against seemed to clear the air. Was there no other way, Nat wondered, to keep the crew in a better frame of mind?

That evening after the storm Nat went to the fo'c'sle. The men hadn't dried out yet from the squall. Oilskins

and jerseys hung everywhere; the stench of sweat and tar slapped Nat in the face as he entered the fo'c'sle.

A man who was talking stopped in midsentence. Eyes turned a sullen stare toward Nat.

Nat said, "Is there any man here who'd like to be master of a ship some day?"

From his mighty six-feet-three Lem Harvey looked down at Nat. When he spoke his words were respectful, but there was the undercurrent of a sneer in his voice. "Who wouldn't, sir? But what chance have we got, sir?"

"The same chance I had!" Nat barked. "In case you want to know, I stopped school when I was ten. I've been sailing by ash breeze ever since. What I've learned, I've picked up here and there, in my spare time. Now, between here and Manila, we're going to have some spare time. Does anyone want to learn some navigation?"

Tom Owens reached a calloused hand and almost broke Nat's fingers with his grip. "We're with you!" he said. "If you can get any navigation in our heads, good for you — sir!" He looked around him. "And if any man don't learn what he can learn, he —"

Lem Harvey stirred.

Tom Owens stopped, then went on lamely. "He — he — ought to be ashamed of himself."

Lem glowered. "You talking to me?"

Tom hesitated. He was a big fellow, but Lem towered over him. Tom mustered a grin, "I'm just talking for myself, Lem."

Lem stepped closer and stood nose to nose with Tom. "Just talking for yourself, eh? See that you remember that."

Nat said, "We'll begin tomorrow. Good night." He returned to the deck and walked slowly aft. What had he done? Made more trouble? Well, whatever happened, he had started it, and he'd have to see it through.

Next day at four bells of the dog watch when the men gathered, Lem was not there. Nat thought to himself, Maybe he'll come around. He began, "Celestial navigation — or sailing by the sky — is what we'll talk about first. All of you know how — when we're close to shore — we figure our position by landmarks. And you know how — when we're out of sight of land — we figure our position by — well — we might call them *sky marks*: the stars, the sun, the moon . . . "

After a little, the men stirred restlessly. Nat felt someone behind him. Out of the corner of his eye he saw Lem Harvey glowering. Nat went on talking, trying to make a far-off star seem more important than Lem Harvey's nearby glare.

The weeks passed. Lem still glowered and muttered. But he was not affecting the crew with his mood now. They were standing a little straighter, and working a little more smartly. It did things to a man, Nat thought, to find out he had a brain.

Near the end of July the *Astrea* reached the Cape.

Johnny shivered. "Brrr! Mighty funny weather for July!"

Nat said, "It's winter at the Cape."

"In July, sir?"

“The weather’s upside down,” Nat told him. And with a cannon ball and a lantern, he showed Johnny how the earth goes around the sun. “You see, the axis of the earth, from the North to the South Pole, leans on a slant — like that. So, as the earth goes around the sun, first

the sun shines straight down on this part, and then on that. Along about the end of June, the sun is shining straight down up here — as far north as it ever does. So north of the equator, where we live, it’s the beginning of summer. But down here, south of the equator, it’s the beginning of winter.”

Johnny shivered again. "I hope it won't be this cold all the way to Manila."

"It won't," Nat promised him. "After we double the Cape, we'll be sailing toward the equator again."

Again the passage around the Cape of Good Hope meant one long struggle against head winds. For three days and nights the watches seemed endless, and the men turned in all standing.

They left the storm behind and sailed north into the Indian Ocean. "I'm glad that's over!" Johnny muttered. Then, a bit glumly, he added, "But there's always something. I wonder what next?"

The "what next" was a warning cry from the lookout. Nat was on watch when it came. "Sail ho-o-o-o-o-o! Off the larboard bow!"

Lem did not wait for a command. He dashed forward bellowing, "All hands on deck and man the guns!" Before the strange ship was close enough for the lookout to see her colors, the guns were cast loose and ready for action. But that was not fast enough for Lem. He roared, "Get those matches lit!" And soon men stood ready, blowing on the end of the long, slow-burning rope to keep it lighted.

Captain Prince was on the quarter-deck with his spy-glass.

Nat hailed the lookout. "What colors is she flying?"

The lookout had never seen the colors before. An ensign with the Union Jack, and red and white stripes.

"Some country ruled by England," Nat said.

Prince's laugh was a short bark. "It's the Flag of the East India Company, Mr. Bowditch."

Nat felt his face get hot. "Oh . . . I thought it was a country."

Prince shrugged. "You weren't so far wrong at that. There's many a nation without half as much power as the East India Company. They've held their charter almost two hundred years. When Queen Elizabeth gave it to them, she gave them enough power to hold their own against the Dutch. They've still got that power.

“They can take over land, wage war, and make peace. They’ve got their own ships, own uniforms, own flags. They’ve got a bigger and better-trained army than we ever had. When England got into this war with France, do you know what the East India Company did? They turned over a dozen frigates, well armed and fully manned — a dozen frigates!”

The ship of the East India Company did not seem interested in the *Astrea*. She held to her course and disappeared.

Lem bellowed, “Secure your guns!” He sounded disgusted.

At the sound of Lem's voice Captain Prince stared toward him. For the first time Nat remembered that Lem wasn't supposed to have charge of the guns. He saw Lem's jaws stiffen, his face grow sullen.

Nat spoke quickly. "Captain Prince, I ordered Lem to handle the guns. He was on my watch, and I —"

Captain Prince said, "I see . . . Send him aft."

Lem Harvey came.

Prince eyed him up and down. At last he spoke. "How did your men do? Were they fast enough?"

Lem's head jerked up. He grinned. "They were terrible, sir! Thumb-fingered fools, the lot of them!"

Captain Prince said, "Mr. Collins, have the men drilled twice a day until further orders. Have Lem and Tom divide the detail."

A smile twitched Collins' face. "Aye, aye, sir."

That night Nat was on deck after his watch, standing at the rail, watching the sky.

"Mr. Bowditch, sir?" a voice rumbled softly.

"Yes, Lem?"

"Begging your pardon, sir, but I didn't hear you order me to handle the guns this morning."

"Didn't you? I guess you were making so much noise yourself you couldn't hear anything."

"Aye, aye, sir." Lem shuffled his feet. "Mr. Bowditch, sir?"

"Yes, Lem?"

"I — I'm dumb. About book learning, I mean. Do you think you could teach me anything without — bawling me out?"

ing me out.
"Yes. But I couldn't teach you much as long as you bawled yourself out."

"Huh . . . sir?"

"I mean — suppose you made a little mistake — or didn't understand something right away. If you wasted my time cursing and yelling 'I can't get that! What's the use?' then I couldn't teach you."

"But — but — " For a long time Lem was silent.

Then he chuckled. "Mr. Bowditch, sir, heaven help you, but you've got yourself a job."

They shook hands on it.

Now, when Nat taught the rest of the crew, Lem stood listening. Whenever Nat and Lem had a spare minute, he taught Lem alone, so that he could catch up with the others. At first it was slow work. In spite of everything, Lem's anger would blaze at himself and he would storm and rage.

Time and again Nat said, "You're wasting time, Lem!"

Finally Lem settled down, and he learned so fast that he surprised even Nat.

The *Astrea* crowded sail now, moving north and east through pleasant weather. Then, so suddenly that it seemed to come between one watch and the next, the steamy heat of the tropics descended. The rigging went slack, tar melted and dripped, the wind died to fitful breezes. Men pumped endless buckets of water and carried them aloft to douse the sails so they would catch what little breeze blew.

Between his watches Nat worked over his notes to figure how to teach the men.

One night, near eight bells of the first watch, Johnny came to Nat's cabin, his teeth chattering with fright. "M-m-m-m-mr. Bowditch, sir, come quick! There's something wrong with the water! We're s-s-s-sailing into something!"

Nat hurried topside. All hands were on deck, standing in silent huddles. Nat went forward to the bow where Collins and Lem were staring into the water.

Johnny's teeth were still chattering. "The ocean's on f-fire. It'll b-b-burn us up!"

It was enough to frighten anyone, Nat admitted to himself. Where the bow of the *Astrea* cut the water, waves of white fire curled back. Captain Prince joined them forward. He stared at the water, too, and ordered a bucket lowered.

Lem bent on a rope, lowered a bucket, and pulled. The bucket rose from the water, rope, bail, and sides dripping white fire. Lem hesitated, swallowed hard, and brought the bucket up.

Captain Prince held a lantern close. The glow disappeared. He ordered the lantern covered, and once more the fire glowed. They leaned close to study the water. In the darkness they could see millions of tiny glowing specks dashing about in the water. "Phosphorescence," he said. He stood by the bow a moment, staring down at the curl of white fire. "What's your course, Mr. Collins?"

"Due east, sir."

"Very good." He turned and strode below.

Lem dumped the water overboard. A cascade of white fire streamed down. Eight bells came. The larboard watch lay below. The men of the starboard watch hesitated, shuffled their feet, then went to their posts.

Lem stalled around the longest. He cleared his throat. "Uh — Mr. Bowditch, sir? What did the captain mean? I mean — if you could think of something for me to tell the others. Some of them are scared, sir."

"You've seen fireflies, haven't you, Lem — lightning bugs?"

"Sure, Mr. Bowditch."

"These must be tiny sea animals that glow in the dark, like fireflies."

Lem released his breath in a long sigh. "Oh, sure. Like fireflies. I'll tell them, sir. Some of the poor fools are scared."

Toward six bells of Nat's watch, the water cleared. Lem swaggered aft. "All gone, ain't it? Too bad, sir. It was kind of pretty."

Nat's watch ended. He was below, and just dropping off to sleep when he heard the cry, "Land ho-o-o-o-o-o!" The lookout must have sighted Java Head. Nat rolled over and went to sleep. If the stories they had heard in Lisbon were true, they would all need rest before they faced the days ahead of them. They must beat their way between Java and Sumatra, fighting against the swift current of Sunda Strait.

The next day they stood off Java Head, waiting for a wind to favor them. Captain Prince was on deck, staring east toward Sunda Strait.

Johnny said, "Mr. Bowditch, sir, how do you sail against a current like that? Like they say it is in Sunda Strait?"

"A simple matter of mathematics, Johnny. If the current against you is flowing at — say — ten knots an hour, you have to be making at least eleven knots to move against it."

8
Captain Prince humphed. "A problem in navigation, Mr. Bowditch. And not so simple. We've got to tack offshore where the wind can reach us. We'll be feeling our way with our lead. And we'll be fighting an uphill sea every mile of Sunda Strait."

The wind veered, freshened, and blew briskly. With every sail spread and bellying taut, the *Astrea* moved sluggishly against the current. Nat looked aloft into the rigging, and found himself clenching his fists and holding his breath, trying to will more speed into his ship.

The wind slackened. The sails lost their taut curves. The *Astrea* shuddered, stood still, and then began to swing sideways in the current pouring like a mighty river through the strait.

Nat jerked to attention and snapped orders. Men dropped the anchors. Hour after hour crawled by, and the waters clawed at the *Astrea*, trying to drive her back. The sun rose to its zenith and poured down merciless heat; afternoon came; then the sudden night of the tropics swallowed them in blackness. But night brought little relief from the heat. Men slumped on the deck and tried to snatch sleep.

At four bells of the first watch the wind freshened. Men leaped to the capstan and heaved the anchor. Slowly the *Astrea* crawled forward, stopped again, and began to swing sideways.

One day — two days — and three — they fought to make headway. Sometimes they moved a mile before they were forced to anchor again; sometimes only half a mile; sometimes it seemed the huge dripping anchors barely broke water before the wind died again. The fourth day, when the *Astrea* lay at anchor, her sails limp, another ship passed them, moving steadily against the current.

Johnny was so angry he almost wept. "Look at that, sir! Look! What's the matter with us? How can that one pass us?"

"She's in ballast and riding high," Nat explained wearily. "Her topsails and royals are catching a breeze that's too high for us."

After one week, the men were hollow-eyed, staggering with weariness. A smart breeze rose abaft the beam. They were almost too tired to cheer, but not too tired to get the *Astrea* under way in jig time. The wind increased. With every sail filled, the *Astrea* heeled over and moved smartly.

Johnny cheered. "Hooray! This time we make it!"

The wind veered sharply and threatened to drive them ashore. They fought to bring the *Astrea* far enough into the wind to keep her from going aground.

The wind died again. They anchored.

Lem Harvey glared down at Johnny. "When we're moving again — if we ever are — you open your mouth, and I'll keelhaul you!" Then he grinned. More and more often Lem topped off a roar with a grin. "Least-wise, I'll have a notion to."



Astrea II entering Manila Harbor

